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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Illinois nursing homes ranked among worst

State places near bottom in US lists, as operators blame low reimbursement rate from Medicaid

By Robert McCoppin
Chicago Tribune

Ebony Payne knows a thing or two about nursing homes. Paralyzed from the neck down after a violent crime, Payne has lived in at least eight nursing homes over the past 20 years.

She knows that when residents ring the call button for help, they're sometimes left waiting for hours, even if they're waiting for assistance getting to the bathroom. Payne, 42, said she once waited 45 minutes for a nursing home worker to come and clean her tracheotomy tube so she could breathe freely.

In some cases, the nursing home facilities themselves are the problem. Payne and other residents have complained about homes with rodents, mold, bathrooms that don't work and the constant smell of urine.

U.S. News & World Report ranked Illinois 47th out of 50 states for nursing home quality, based on federal reports of health inspections, staffing and other quality measures. A 2019 analy-

sis by Families for Better Care, a nonprofit advocacy group, ranked Illinois 49th.

And a Tribune search of records kept by the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services showed Illinois has some 250 homes with a quality rating of just one star out of five.

To be sure, more than six dozen of the roughly 1,200 long-term care facilities in the state have earned all five stars. But advocates like Payne say that at too many nurs-

ing homes, profits are prioritized over care.

"They all operate on the same business model," Payne said. "That's getting as much money out of each facility as possible."

Nursing home operators say much of the problem comes from Illinois' Medicaid reimbursement rate, which they say is lower than most other states and doesn't fully

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NASCAR IN CHICAGO



AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

RACE DAY SHOWER CAP

Aaron Moy looks for drivers walking through Grant Park before the NASCAR Cup Series Grant Park 165 on Sunday. After previous years were interrupted by storms, fans came ready for the weather, but this time the downpour waited until after the race was finished.

Coverage on Page 4 and in Chicago Sports

Death toll increases in Texas flooding

Officials report 10 campers still missing as search goes on

By Jim Vertuno and John Seewer
Associated Press

KERRVILLE, Texas — Families sifted through waterlogged debris Sunday and stepped inside empty cabins at Camp Mystic, an all-girls summer camp ripped apart by flash floods that washed homes off their foundations.

The central Texas flooding killed at least 79 people.

Rescuers maneuvering through challenging terrain continued their desperate search for the missing, including 10 girls and a counselor from the camp. How many more remain unaccounted for across the Texas Hill Country and beyond remains unclear as authorities haven't given an estimate even though it has been three days since the storm began pounding the state.

In Kerr County, home to Camp Mystic and other youth camps, searchers have found 16 bodies since Saturday afternoon, bringing the total number of dead there

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Erica Baker teaches her grandson Messiah, 6, how to ride his bike outside their home June 10 in Dolton. Pope Leo XIV grew up in the village south of Chicago. BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Pope's hometown unremarkable, but special in its own way

Long after the fuss dies down, the village of Dolton will still be here

By Christopher Borrelli
Chicago Tribune

The village of Dolton, which is where you may find yourself if you're traveling south through Chicago and run out of Chicago to travel through, which we have heard more about in the past 30 days or so than since it was established 130-odd years ago, which is now best known to the world

as the hometown of Pope Leo XIV, is like a lot of Midwestern places. Or a lot of the blink-and-you-miss-it boondocks, backwaters and wherever other popes have come from.

You never give it a second thought, until you do.

And so, before our attention swings forever more to the Vatican, know this:

Dolton, whether or not you ever think about it again, is

full of kindness and hope. But interesting. It's a pocket-sized village (4.6 square miles, with a population that peaked at around 26,000 in 1970 and has drifted off ever since). It's on the banks of muddy Little Calumet River and modest Lake Cottage Grove, though it feels far from anything damp. The town water tower always

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Efforts to rein in AI get mixed results

Legislators weigh restrictions on use in education, mental health care, elections

By Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

Illinois lawmakers have so far achieved mixed results in efforts to regulate the burgeoning technology of artificial intelligence, a task that butts up against moves by the Trump administration to eliminate restrictions on AI.

AI-related bills introduced during the spring legislative session covered areas including education, health care, insurance and elections. Supporters say the measures are intended to address potential threats to public safety or personal privacy and to counter any deceitful actions facilitated by AI, while not hindering innovation.

Although several of those measures failed to come to a vote, the Democratic-controlled General Assembly is only six months into its two-year term and all of the legislation remains in play. But going forward, backers will have to contend with Republican President Donald Trump's administration's plans to approach AI.

Days into Trump's second term in January, his administration rescinded a 2023 executive order from Democratic President Joe Biden, that emphasized the "highest urgency on governing the development and use of AI safely and responsibly."

Trump replaced that policy with a declaration that "revokes certain existing AI policies and directives that act as barriers to American AI innovation."

Last week, the states got a reprieve from the federal government after a provision aimed at preventing states from regulating AI was removed from the massive, Trump-backed tax breaks bill that he signed into law. Still, Democratic Illinois state Rep. Abdelnasser Rashid, who co-chaired a legislative task force on AI last year, criticized Trump's decision to rescind Biden's AI executive order that Rashid said "set us on a positive

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Rally responds to mass shootings

Several dozen people gathered for a march and rally Sunday in River North to decry a recent spate of mass shootings, including one that left four dead and 14 wounded. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Gaza ceasefire plan details emerge

The 60-day proposal would have Hamas hand over 10 living and 18 dead hostages, while Israeli forces would withdraw to a buffer zone and significant aid would be brought in. **Nation & World**

